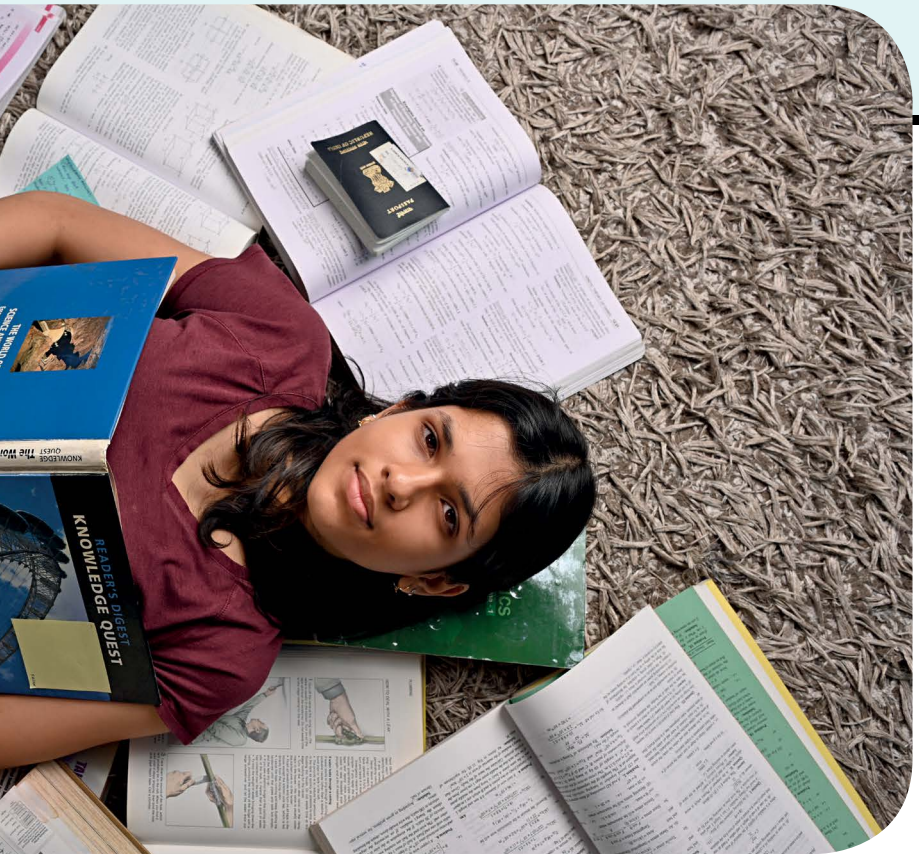


DEVANSHI SOOD, *18,*
Gurugram

» **GOING FOR:** Bachelor's in Computational Media, Georgia Institute of Technology, US

» **WHY SHE WANTS TO GO**

"I am interested in environment technology and I feel the degree will offer me room to experiment. There is also a huge market for this particular subject in the US"

To attract international students, foreign universities are working hard to demystify application processes, devise student-friendly visa policies and offer attractive scholarships, which can significantly reduce tuition and living expenses. They range from full scholarships that cover all expenses of a student to merit-based financial awards granted to students by universities or external organisations. The graduate research assistantships (GRA), for instance, allow graduate students to engage in research activities under the supervision of a faculty member. GRAs usually receive a stipend and may have their tuition fees waived or reduced in lieu of research work. Graduate teaching assistantships (GTA) are another incentive—they are provided to graduate students who assist faculty members with teaching-related tasks. GTAs, too, earn a stipend and a tuition fee waiver or reduction.

Many countries have also begun offering attractive immigration and post-study work opportunities to foreign students. If Canada has a Postgraduation Work Permit Programme, the US has something called the STEM OPT or Optional Practical Training Extension for STEM Students visa programme, under which international students can extend their work authorisation by a year. Australia has extended post-study visa work duration from two to three years while in the UK, as Prof. Jeffery points out, "The Graduate Immigration Route that allows students to undertake post-study work in the UK is a key factor in the appeal of our universities to Indian students in particular."

All of which reassures Indian aspirants that foreign education does not have to be a pipe dream. Canada remains a top draw due to its welcoming immigration policies, high quality of education and relatively cheaper tuition fees compared to the US and UK. If the average annual cost of a four-year undergraduate degree in the US is $40,000-$55,000 (Rs 33 lakh-Rs 45 lakh) and approximately £22,000 (Rs 23 lakh) per year for a three-year undergraduate degree in the UK, an undergraduate programme in Canada works out to CAD 20,000-35,000 (Rs 12.4-21.7 lakh) per year. The US and UK attract substantial number of students owing to the number of top-ranked universities and the large Indian diasporas there. Australia remains another lure, given its high standard of living, world-class education system and work opportunities after graduation. An undergraduate programme here costs AUD 20,000-40,000 (Rs 11-22 lakh) per year.

However, even as Anglophone countries remain the preferred destinations for Indian students, countries like France, Italy and Germany attract numerous applications from India (see *Abroad Spectrum*). In fact, as the ministry of external affairs informed Parliament in February this year, you will find Indians in 240 countries and territories around the world. Canada, Australia, the US and the UK remain the top choices, but sizeable numbers are also travelling to Uzbekistan, the Philippines, Russia, Ireland, Kyrgyzstan and Kazakhstan. As the saying goes, the world is your oyster. ■